

Hannah Estes (hmestes@ncsu.edu), Satwika Kancharla (skancha5@ncsu.edu), Katie Stolee (ktstolee@ncsu.edu)

MOTIVATION

- **Resolve Role Ambiguity** by clarifying the **all-in-one** nature of the software product manager (SPM) role
- **Align Expectations** between formal job descriptions and the actual work software teams (including SPMs) expect
- **Address the Information Needs** of the software team to better collaboration
- **Reduce Team Friction** when working with SPMs

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

RQ1: What **<actions, knowledge>** characterize(s) the involvement of SPMs on a software team?

RQ2: How well do the actual job responsibilities of software product managers **align with stated expectations?**

RQ3: What **problematic experiences** do software teams report while working with software product managers?

CONTRIBUTIONS

- **Eight overarching software product manager responsibilities** to assess role expectations from the software team.
- A **taxonomy of 81 questions** that software teams typically ask
- **Eight problematic experience categories** when working with software product managers
- An **evaluation of extra-role expectations** comparing the software team and organizational perspectives
- The **SPM Expectations Nested in Software Engineering (SENSE) framework**

NEXT STEPS

- Find solutions to the problems that software teams face
- Identify how advocacy directly shapes the SPM role and their interactions with stakeholders
- Distinguish how perceptions of SPMs differ across multiple dimensions:
 - customer type
 - product maturity
 - team size
 - SPM seniority and experience.
- Clarification of Extra-Role Performance Expectations
- Capitalizing on Opportunities for AI in Software Product Management

RESULTS

RQ1 : SOFTWARE TEAM EXPECTATIONS

Action Expectations (SPM Role)

Knowledge Expectations (SPM Questions)

Role Identifier

⚙️ PF : 45

🔍 EF : 35

Σ 80 / 80

↓

SPM Question

⚙️ PF : 39

🔍 EF : 32

Σ 71 / 80

↓

SPM Role

⚙️ PF : 39

🔍 EF : 30

Σ 69 / 80

↓

SPM Problem

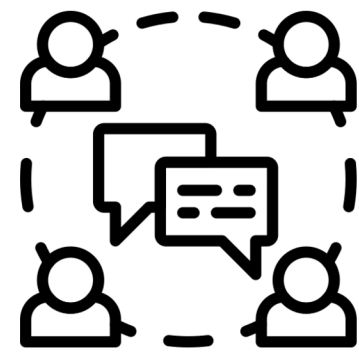
⚙️ PF : 26

🔍 EF : 17

Σ 43 / 61



Product Expert



Communication Guru



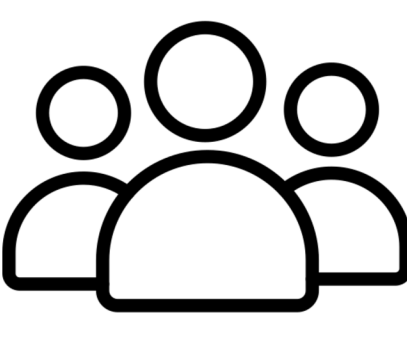
User Advocate



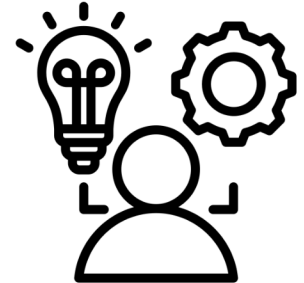
Product



Logistics

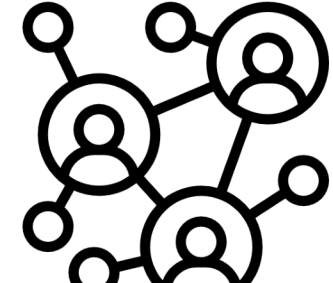


Users



Comprehension

Problematic Experiences (SPM Problems)



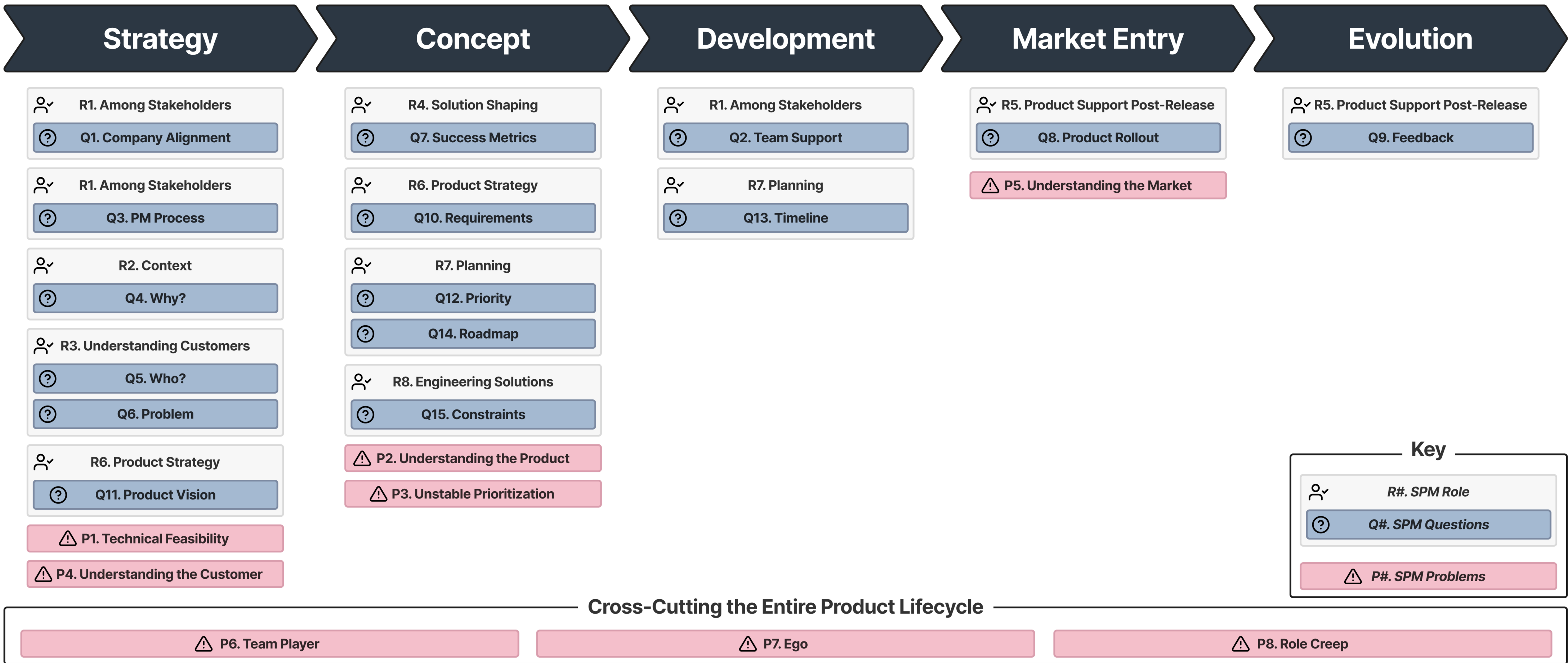
Cooperation

RQ2: 37 JOB DESCRIPTIONS

- There is little reference to working explicitly with the **software team**.
- 89% of job descriptions emphasize **stakeholder coordination**, but only 32% mention **how** the SPM should.
- Only 11% mention conveying **context** even though this is very important from the team perspective.
- Understanding software **constraints** was described by 2 companies (5%).

SENSE FRAMEWORK

SPM Expectations Nested in Software Engineering



SPM'S VALUE MAPPING

An SPM's value stems from their ability to provide the team with **direction** and a **plan**, give **context for decision-making**, and **effectively communicate** across stakeholders.



FSE-SEET
Prior Work



Value

Planning

Understanding the Product Context

Communication



Problem

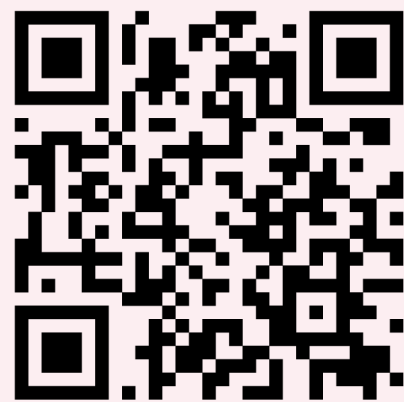
Unstable Prioritization

Understanding the {Product | Customer | Market} & Technical Feasibility

Team Player | Ego

THANK YOU!

Thank you to my labmates, collaborators, and my advisor, Dr. Katie Stolee!



Contact Me!